

THEME 1 · B2.1

School Life & Education

Comparing different school systems (local and international)

Comparing different education systems

School traditions, events, and celebration activities

National days and celebrations

Warm-up

Look at the title: School Life & Education. What do you think we will talk about in this theme? Tell your partner two ideas.

VOCABULARY

New words

20 target words

compulsory education

n. phrase



zorunlu eğitim

Compulsory education in Türkiye starts at age six.

curriculum

n.



müfredat

The new curriculum includes more project-based learning.

boarding school

n. phrase



yatılı okul

She moved to a boarding school in another city for high school.

state school

n. phrase



devlet okulu

Most children in Türkiye attend state schools.

private school

n. phrase



özel okul

Private schools often have smaller classes.

grade / year

n.



sınıf (seviye)

My cousin is in the ninth grade this year.

timetable

n.



ders programı

Check the timetable — we have Chemistry first today.

assembly

n.



toplantı, tören

The head teacher spoke at the morning assembly.

extracurricular activity

n. phrase



ders dışı etkinlik

He joined the chess club as an extracurricular activity.

tradition

n.



gelenek

Wearing a cap and gown at graduation is a long tradition.

graduation ceremony

n. phrase



mezuniyet töreni

Our graduation ceremony will be held in the school garden.

national day

n. phrase



milli bayram

Schools organise special programmes on national days.

commemorate

v.



anmak

The school commemorates its founder every October.

celebration

n.



kutlama

The end-of-term celebration includes music and food.

exchange programme

n. phrase



değişim programı

She spent a term in Italy on an exchange programme.

assessment

n.



değerlendirme

Continuous assessment counts for 40% of the final grade.

peer

n.



akran

Peer feedback helped me improve my essay.

vocational school

n. phrase



meslek okulu

He chose a vocational school to train as an electrician.

academic year

n. phrase



eğitim öğretim yılı

The academic year is divided into two terms here.

diverse

adj.



çeşitli, farklı

Our class is diverse — students come from five different cities.

Quick game · What's the word?

“**milli bayram**”

a national day

b private school

c vocational school

Quick game · What's the word?

“sınıf (seviye)”

a grade / year

b exchange programme

c tradition

Quick game · What's the word?

“meslek okulu”

a boarding school

b graduation ceremony

c vocational school

Quick game · What's the word?

“çeşitli, farklı”

a vocational school

b diverse

c boarding school

Quick game · What's the word?

“gelenek”

a grade / year

b tradition

c assessment

Quick game · What's the word?

“zorunlu eğitim”

a national day

b private school

c compulsory education

GRAMMAR

Simple Present vs Present Progressive + Adverbs of Frequency

Notice

In Finland, the school day usually **starts** at 9 a.m.

Look — the students in this photo **are wearing** everyday clothes, not uniforms.

Our school **always holds** an assembly on Mondays, but this week we **are having** it on Tuesday because of the holiday.

She **rarely misses** school, but today she **is missing** the first lesson because of a dentist appointment.

Which sentences describe something that usually happens, and which describe something happening right now or temporarily? Where do the adverbs of frequency (always, rarely) go?

Complete the rule

Look at the Notice sentences again. Complete the rule with the words in the box.

is/are + -ing

before the main verb

base verb (+s/es)

temporary or right now

Complete the rule

For things that usually / generally happen, we use the Simple Present: _____ .

✓ base verb (+s/es)

Complete the rule

For things happening right now or _____, we use the Present Progressive: _____.

✓ temporary or right now / is/are + -ing

Complete the rule

Adverbs of frequency (always, usually, rarely) usually go

_____ .

✓ **before the main verb**

The rule

The Simple Present describes facts, habits and things that happen regularly (add -s/-es with he/she/it). The Present Progressive (be + -ing) describes something happening now or temporarily. Adverbs of frequency (always, usually, often, rarely, never) go before the main verb, but after the verb 'be'.

TR Simple Present, genel gerçekleri, alışkanlıkları ve düzenli olan şeyleri anlatır (he/she/it ile -s/-es). Present Progressive (be + -ing) ise şu anda olan ya da geçici olan bir durumu anlatır. Sıklık zarfları (always, usually, often, rarely, never) ana fiilden ÖNCE, be fiilinden SONRA gelir.

When? Use the Simple Present for timetables, habits and general rules; use the Present Progressive for something happening now, or a temporary change this week or term.

TR Okul programlarını, alışkanlıkları ve genel kuralları anlatırken Simple Present; şu anda olan bir şeyi ya da bu hafta/dönem geçici bir değişikliği anlatırken Present Progressive kullanırız.

Build sentences · Example

Finnish students

+

usually / start

+

school at 9 a.m.

Finnish students usually start school at 9 a.m.

Build sentences

our school

+

always / hold

+

assembly on Mondays

Our school always holds an assembly on Mondays.

Build sentences

this week / we

+

have

+

it on Tuesday (now)

This week we are having it on Tuesday.

Build sentences

she + rarely / miss + school

She rarely misses school.

Build sentences

look — the students

+

wear

+

everyday clothes (right now)

Look — the students are wearing everyday clothes.

Build sentences

? / your school

+

ever / celebrate

+

an international day

Does your school ever celebrate an international day?

Your turn

Write four sentences about your own school day: one general routine, one thing you rarely/always do, and one thing happening this week that is different from usual.

My school usually...

I always/rarely...

This week, we are...

Right now, our class...

Form

POSITIVE

School usually starts at 9.
We are having assembly today.

NEGATIVE

He doesn't wear a uniform.
They aren't studying Chemistry this term.

QUESTION

Does your school celebrate national days?
Is she wearing the new uniform?

SHORT ANSWERS

Yes, it does. / No, it doesn't.
Yes, she is. / No, she isn't.

Error detective

She is always missing the bus.

a Correct

b Incorrect

✓ **She always misses the bus.**

Error detective

Look, she wears a new badge today!

a Correct

b Incorrect

✓ **Look, she is wearing a new badge today!**

Error detective

He always is late.

a Correct

b Incorrect

✓ **He is always late.**

A • Choose the correct option.

Our school day _____ at 9 o'clock.

a starts

b is starting

c start

A • Choose the correct option.

Look! The new students _____ around the building for the first time.

a walk

b are walking

c walks

A • Choose the correct option.

She _____ misses her deadlines — she's very organised.

a rarely

b is rarely

c rarelys

A • Choose the correct option.

This term, our class _____ a new subject.

a study

b is studying

c studies

B · Complete with the correct form.

Our school _____ (hold) its sports day every May.

✓ holds

B · Complete with the correct form.

_____ your school _____ (celebrate) any international days? (question)

✓ **does / celebrate**

B · Complete with the correct form.

Right now, the head teacher _____ (give) a speech in the hall.

✓ is giving

C · Judge the sentence.

He is usually arriving early.

a Correct

b Incorrect

✓ **He usually arrives early.**

C · Judge the sentence.

This week we are trialling a new timetable.

a Correct

b Incorrect

Dialogue · Complete with Simple Present or Present Progressive.

A: What _____ your school usually _____ (do) for national days?

✓ **does / do**

Dialogue · Complete with Simple Present or Present Progressive.

B: We _____ (have) a flag ceremony every year, but this year we _____ also _____ (prepare) a short play.

✓ have / are also preparing

Dialogue · Reorder the question.

does / your school / national days / celebrate / how

days

national

school

does

your

how

celebrate

?

✓ **How does your school celebrate national days?**

GRAMMAR

Polite Requests and Offers: may / might / can / could / shall

Notice

Could you tell me the school's start time, please?

May I ask a question about the exchange programme?

Shall I read the announcement to the class?

Can you explain the new timetable to me?

Which modal verbs make a request sound very polite/formal, and which one offers to do something for someone?

Complete the rule

Complete the rule with the words in the box.

offer to do something

may / could

can / could

Complete the rule

To ask someone politely to do something, we use _____ + subject + base verb.

✓ **can / could**

Complete the rule

_____ + I is a very formal way to ask for permission or information.

✓ may / could

Complete the rule

'Shall I...?' is used to _____ for someone.

✓ offer to do something

The rule

Use can/could to make polite requests (could is more formal/polite). Use may/might to ask permission very formally. Use 'Shall I...?' to offer to do something for someone.

TR Nazik ricalar için can/could kullanılır (could daha resmi/naziktir). May/might izin isterken çok resmi bir ton verir. 'Shall I...?' bir şey yapmayı teklif etmek için kullanılır.

When? We use these patterns when we ask a teacher, a guest or someone we don't know well for something, or when we offer to help.

TR Öğretmenden, misafirden ya da tanımadığın birinden bir şey isterken ya da bir şey teklif ederken bu kalıpları kullanırız.

Build sentences · Example

Tell me the rule. (could)

Could you tell me the rule, please?

Build sentences

Explain the timetable. (can)

Can you explain the timetable, please?

Build sentences

Ask a question. (may)

May I ask a question?

Build sentences

Read the announcement. (shall, offer)

Shall I read the announcement?

Build sentences

Open the window. (could)

Could you open the window, please?

Build sentences

Use your phone for research. (might)

Might I use my phone for research?

Your turn

Write three polite requests or offers you could make at school this week — one with 'could', one with 'may', and one offer with 'shall'.

Could you...

May I...

Shall I...

Form

POSITIVE

Could you help me, please?
Shall I close the door?

NEGATIVE

You may not use your
phone during the test.
Could you not talk so
loudly, please?

QUESTION

May I leave early today?
Can you repeat that,
please?

SHORT ANSWERS

Of course. / I'm afraid not.
Yes, please. / No, thanks,
it's fine.

Error detective

Can I to ask a question?

a Correct

b Incorrect

✓ **Can I ask a question?**

Error detective

Shall you help me?

a Correct

b Incorrect

✓ **Shall I help you? / Could you help me?**

A • Choose the correct option.

_____ I ask you something about the new curriculum?

a May

b Shall

c Must

A • Choose the correct option.

_____ I carry your books for you?

a Can

b Shall

c May

A • Choose the correct option.

_____ you explain the assessment rules again, please?

a Could

b Shall

c Must

B · Complete with the correct modal.

_____ I use the library computer for my project?

✓ May / Could / Can

B · Complete with the correct modal.

_____ I turn on the lights for you?

✓ Shall

C · Judge the sentence.

Could you to help me with the timetable?

a Correct

b Incorrect

✓ **Could you help me with the timetable?**

C · Judge the sentence.

Shall I read the assembly announcement today?

a Correct

b Incorrect

Dialogue · Complete with the correct modal.

A: _____ you help me understand the exchange programme rules?

✓ Could / Can

Dialogue · Complete with the correct modal.

B: Of course. _____ I show you the leaflet?

✓ **Shall**

GRAMMAR

Question Tags (Simple Present & Present Progressive)

Notice

Your school starts at nine, **doesn't it**?

You aren't in the exchange programme, **are you**?

She teaches Geography, **doesn't she**?

We're preparing for the ceremony, **aren't we**?

When the main sentence is positive, is the tag positive or negative? What happens after a negative sentence?

Complete the rule

Complete the rule with the words in the box.

negative

positive

same auxiliary/be verb

Complete the rule

A positive sentence takes a _____ tag.

✓ **negative**

Complete the rule

A negative sentence takes a _____ tag.

✓ **positive**

Complete the rule

The tag uses the _____ as the main sentence (does/doesn't, is/isn't...).

✓ **same auxiliary/be verb**

The rule

A question tag confirms information: a positive statement takes a negative tag, and a negative statement takes a positive tag. The tag repeats the auxiliary or 'be' verb from the main sentence.

TR Question tag, olumlu cümleye olumsuz, olumsuz cümleye olumlu bir 'kısasoru' eklenerek teyit istemek için kullanılır. Yardımcı fiil ya da be fiili ana cümledekiyle aynı olur.

When? We use question tags to check information or to keep a conversation going.

TR Bir bilgiyi teyit etmek ya da sohbeti sürdürmek istediğimizde question tag kullanırız.

Build sentences · Example

Your school has an assembly every Monday, ____?

Your school has an assembly every Monday, doesn't it?

Build sentences

She doesn't like exams, ____?

She doesn't like exams, does she?

Build sentences

They are organising the ceremony, ____?

They are organising the ceremony, aren't they?

Build sentences

You don't wear a uniform at your school, ____?

You don't wear a uniform at your school, do you?

Build sentences

The head teacher gives a speech every term, ____?

The head teacher gives a speech every term, doesn't he/she?

Your turn

Write three true or false statements about your school with question tags, and ask a partner to confirm them.

Our school..., doesn't it?

We..., don't we?

The teachers..., do they?

Form

POSITIVE

Your school starts at nine,
doesn't it?

NEGATIVE

You aren't in the exchange
programme, are you?

QUESTION

She teaches Geography,
doesn't she?

SHORT ANSWERS

Yes, it does. / No, it doesn't.

Error detective

She teaches Geography, doesn't teach she?

a Correct

b Incorrect

✓ **She teaches Geography, doesn't she?**

A • Choose the correct tag.

Your school has a big library, _____?

a doesn't it

b does it

c isn't it

A • Choose the correct tag.

You aren't studying for the test tonight, _____?

a are you

b aren't you

c do you

B · Complete with the correct tag.

The students are preparing a project, _____ ?

✓ **aren't they**

B · Complete with the correct tag.

He doesn't enjoy assemblies, _____?

✓ **does he**

C · Judge the sentence.

We're having a celebration today, isn't it?

a Correct

b Incorrect

✓ **We're having a celebration today, aren't we?**

Dialogue · Add the tag.

Your school celebrates Teachers' Day every year, _____ ?

✓ **doesn't it**

GRAMMAR

Articles and Quantifiers

Notice

Our school has **a** big library and **an** outdoor sports hall.

Some schools give homework every day; **few** schools give none at all.

There isn't **much** information about the exchange programme on the website yet.

Many students take part in **the** annual sports day.

When do we use 'a' and when do we use 'an'? Which quantifiers go with countable nouns, and which with uncountable nouns?

Complete the rule

Complete the rule with the words in the box.

a vowel sound

countable

uncountable

the

Complete the rule

We use 'an' before a word that starts with _____.

✓ **a vowel sound**

Complete the rule

'Many' and 'few' are used with _____ nouns (students, schools).

✓ **countable**

Complete the rule

'Much' and 'little' are used with _____ nouns (information, homework).

✓ **uncountable**

Complete the rule

We use _____ for something specific that both speakers know about.

✓ **the**

The rule

'A' comes before a consonant sound, 'an' before a vowel sound. 'The' is used for something specific/known. Many/few go with countable nouns, much/little with uncountable nouns; some/a lot of work with both.

TR 'A' sessiz harfle, 'an' ise sesli harf sesiyle başlayan kelimelerden önce kullanılır. 'The' belirli/bilinen bir şey için kullanılır. Sayılabilir isimlerle many/few, sayılamayan isimlerle much/little; her ikisiyle de some/a lot of kullanılabilir.

When? We need the correct articles and quantifiers when we describe a school's facilities, rules and statistics.

TR Okulun imkanlarını, kurallarını ve istatistiklerini anlatırken doğru miktar belirteçlerini ve tanımlıkları kullanmamız gerekir.

Build sentences · Example

Our school has ____ excellent music room.

Our school has an excellent music room.

Build sentences

___ students choose the vocational track after Grade 9.

Many students choose the vocational track after Grade 9.

Build sentences

There is ____ information about school rules in the handbook.

There is some information about school rules in the handbook.

Build sentences

We don't have ____ time before ____ assembly starts.

We don't have much time before the assembly starts.

Build sentences

Only ____ schools in our city have a full-size swimming pool.

Only a few schools in our city have a full-size swimming pool.

Your turn

Describe your school's facilities using a/an/the and at least two quantifiers (some, many, much, few, a lot of).

Our school has a/an...

There are many/few...

We don't have much...

Form

POSITIVE

Our school has a large library.
Many students join a club.

NEGATIVE

We don't have much free time.
Few schools offer this subject.

QUESTION

How much homework do you get?
How many clubs does your school have?

SHORT ANSWERS

A lot. / Not much.
Many. / Only a few.

Error detective

We have much clubs at school.

a Correct

b Incorrect

✓ **We have many clubs at school.**

Error detective

She goes to a university near here.

a Correct

b Incorrect

✓ **She goes to the university near here. / She goes to a university near here.**

A • Choose the correct option.

Our school has _____ excellent science lab.

a a

b an

c the

A • Choose the correct option.

How _____ students are there in your class?

a much

b many

c little

A • Choose the correct option.

There isn't _____ information about the trip yet.

a many

b much

c few

B · Complete with a/an/the.

_____ head teacher of our school gave _____ inspiring speech.

✓ The / an

C · Judge the sentence.

Few schools in our region offer this vocational course.

a Correct

b Incorrect

C · Judge the sentence.

We don't have many time for extracurricular activities.

a Correct

b Incorrect

✓ **We don't have much time for extracurricular activities.**

Text · Complete with a/an/the/some/many/much.

Our school is _____ old building with _____ large courtyard. _____ students walk to school, but not _____.

✓ **an / a / Many / many**

READING

Two Very Different School Days

Before you read

1. Look at the title. What two schools do you think this text compares?
2. What do you already know about school systems outside Türkiye?

TWO VERY DIFFERENT SCHOOL DAYS · 1 / 3

In Helsinki, sixteen-year-old Aino's school day starts at 9 a.m. and finishes by 2 p.m. There are shorter lessons, more breaks, and almost no homework — but students are expected to manage their own study time responsibly. Teachers know their students well because class groups often stay together for years, and assessment relies more on projects and discussion than on final exams.

TWO VERY DIFFERENT SCHOOL DAYS · 2 / 3

Halfway around the world, in Singapore, Wei-Lin's school day begins earlier and runs later, often followed by extra classes or club activities until early evening. The curriculum is demanding, and national exams play a major role in deciding which secondary school — and later, which university — a student can attend. Parents and teachers place a strong emphasis on discipline, hard work, and academic results.

TWO VERY DIFFERENT SCHOOL DAYS · 3 / 3

Despite these differences, both systems share a clear goal: helping young people build the knowledge and skills they need for adult life. Finland focuses on independence, well-being, and creativity; Singapore focuses on rigour, structure, and achievement. Educators around the world often study both systems, borrowing ideas from each to design programmes that suit their own students best.

While you read

What is the main idea of the text?

a Finland's system is better than Singapore's.

b Finland and Singapore have very different school systems with the same overall goal.

c Both countries have exactly the same school day.

While you read

In Singapore, _____ often play a major role in deciding which school a student can attend.

✓ **national exams**

While you read

According to the text, Finnish schools focus more on:

a discipline and exam results

b independence, well-being and creativity

c longer school days

While you read

Aino's school day is longer than Wei-Lin's.

a Correct

b Incorrect

✓ **Wei-Lin's school day is longer than Aino's.**

While you read

Class groups in Finland often stay together for _____, which helps teachers know their students well.

✓ years

After you read

1. Which system would you rather study in — Finland's or Singapore's? Why?
2. Write one sentence comparing your own school day to Aino's or Wei-Lin's.

READING

A Guide to Our School Traditions

Before you read

1. What traditions or events does your own school have?
2. Do you think school traditions are important? Why or why not?

A GUIDE TO OUR SCHOOL TRADITIONS · 1 / 3

Every school develops its own traditions over time, and ours is no different. Each September, new students take part in a Welcome Festival, where older students act as guides for a day, introducing them to the building, the clubs, and a few unwritten rules of school life. It's a simple event, but it helps everyone feel like part of the community from day one.

A GUIDE TO OUR SCHOOL TRADITIONS · 2 / 3

In October, the whole school gathers for the Republic Day assembly, where students present short readings, songs, and a display about national history. Preparation begins weeks in advance, with different classes responsible for different parts of the programme — a good chance to practise teamwork as well as public speaking.

A GUIDE TO OUR SCHOOL TRADITIONS · 3 / 3

Perhaps the most popular tradition is the end-of-year Talent Show, when students can perform music, dance, comedy, or short plays in front of the whole school. Anyone can take part, and the atmosphere is always supportive rather than competitive. For many students, it's their favourite memory of the whole school year, and a reminder that school is about more than lessons and exams.

While you read

What is the purpose of the Welcome Festival?

a To test new students' English

b To help new students feel part of the school community

c To choose the best students

While you read

The Republic Day assembly includes short readings, songs, and a display about _____.

✓ **national history**

While you read

The Talent Show is a competition with prizes for the winners.

a Correct

b Incorrect

✓ The Talent Show is supportive rather than competitive, with no mention of prizes.

While you read

Why does the writer say the Talent Show is many students' favourite memory?

a

Because it's the easiest event

b

Because it shows school is more than lessons and exams

c

Because it happens every month

After you read

1. Does your own school have a tradition similar to the Talent Show? Describe it.
2. Do you think every school should have a Welcome Festival for new students? Why or why not?

LISTENING

Comparing Schools — A Video Call

Before you listen

1. Predict: what three things do you think Elif and Marta will compare?

Comparing Schools — A Video Call

Ses kaydı yakında — transkripti öğretmen okuyabilir.

While you listen

What time does Marta's school start?

a 8:00

b 8:15

c 9:00

While you listen

Marta's school requires a uniform.

a Correct

b Incorrect

✓ **Marta's school does not require a uniform.**

While you listen

Elif offers to send Marta some _____ from last year's assembly.

✓ photos

While you listen

In the question 'Do you wear a school uniform?', the intonation typically:

a rises at the end

b falls at the end

c stays flat

LISTENING

School Traditions Around the World — A Short Talk

Before you listen

1. What tradition would you choose to research if you did this project?

School Traditions Around the World — A Short Talk

Ses kaydı yakında — transkripti öğretmen okuyabilir.

While you listen

What is the main task the teacher describes?

a Write an essay about Türkiye

b Research and present a school tradition from another country

c Organise the school's own assembly

While you listen

Students should find at least _____ reliable sources.

✓ two

While you listen

Students will present individually.

a Correct

b Incorrect

✓ **Students will present in pairs.**

SPEAKING

Comparing School Systems

In pairs, compare your own school with one of the two schools from Reading 1 (Finland or Singapore). Talk about the school day, uniforms, exams, and homework. Use at least three question tags to check your partner's understanding, and practise both rising and falling intonation.

SPEAKING

Our School Traditions — A Mini-Presentation

Prepare a two-minute talk introducing one tradition from your own school (or one you would like your school to have) to an international visitor. Explain what happens, when it happens, and why it matters to students.

WRITING

An FAQ Page About Our School

Write an FAQ page (5–6 questions and answers) for an international student who is about to join your school. Cover the school day, uniform, subjects, and one tradition.

WRITING

A Blog Post: Comparing School Systems

Write a blog post comparing your school system with one from Reading 1 (Finland or Singapore). Give at least three points of comparison and your own opinion at the end.

REVIEW

Exit ticket

Exit ticket

Our school _____ its Welcome Festival every September.

a hold

b holds

c is holding

Exit ticket

_____ you tell me what time assembly starts, please?

a Could

b Must

c Shall

Exit ticket

Look! The new students _____ (explore) the building right now.

✓ are exploring

Exit ticket

She teaches Chemistry, _____ ?

✓ doesn't she

Exit ticket

There isn't _____ information about the trip yet.

a many

b much

c few

Exit ticket

Shall you help me carry these books?

a Correct

b Incorrect

✓ **Shall I help you carry these books?**

Exit ticket

We don't have _____ clubs at our school compared to theirs.
(few/many)

✓ many

Exit ticket

Which sentence uses the Present Progressive correctly for a temporary situation?

a We always have PE on Fridays.

b This term, we are having PE on Thursdays instead.

c We have PE on Thursdays always.

Exit ticket

Which is the most polite way to ask for a club sign-up form?

a Give me the form.

b Could I possibly get an application form for the Chess Club?

c I join Chess Club now.

Exit ticket

Excuse me, _____ you tell me where the school office is?

✓ could / Could

Exit ticket

Put the words in order.

wear

uniform

every

students

school

the

must

day

•

✓ **Students must wear the school uniform every day.**

Exit ticket

The exam start at nine o'clock tomorrow.

a Correct

b Incorrect

✓ **The exam starts at nine o'clock tomorrow.**

Exit ticket

Rewrite the sentence with a question tag.

(The new library opens next Monday.)

✓ **The new library opens next Monday, doesn't it?**

Exit ticket

There are _____ interesting clubs to choose from this year.
(few/many)

✓ many